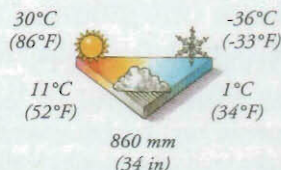


Iceland

 The island country of Iceland lies far north in the Atlantic, midway between Europe and North America, and is increasingly important for international communications. Its position on the Mid-Atlantic Ridge means it has many volcanoes and is prone to earthquakes. Iceland has been a republic since 1944.

Climate

Owing to the Gulf Stream, Iceland's southern lowlands are mild and breezy, and snow is rare. The north is colder, but less windy.



Physical features

Iceland is a land of fire and ice, where steaming hot volcanic springs bubble up through glaciers. The centre consists of uninhabitable plateaus and mountains. In the south are farmlands. There are many rivers, lakes, and spectacular waterfalls.



Volcanoes

The island of Little Surtsey is a volcano that rose from the sea close to Iceland in spring 1965, but disappeared again the following winter. Mainland Iceland has at least 20 active volcanoes that could erupt at any time.

Glaciers

Europe's largest ice-caps cover over one-tenth of Iceland. The biggest is Vatnajökull, which covers an area of 8,133 sq km (3,149 sq miles) in the southeast of the country.

Geothermal power

Every year, thousands of people visit the Blue Lagoon, to swim in this natural pool of healing, geothermal, mineral-rich sea water. Vast resources ensure that hydroelectric and geothermal power stations meet almost all of Iceland's electricity needs.

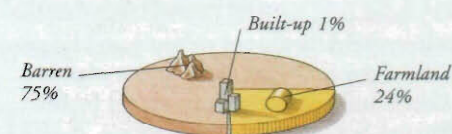
Fishing

Iceland relies on exporting fish to pay for all the necessities of modern living, which are imported from abroad. Fishing and fish processing are Iceland's leading industries and employ around 20 per cent of the labour force.



ICELAND FACTS

CAPITAL CITY	Reykjavik
AREA	100,250 sq km (38,707 sq miles)
POPULATION	281,000
MAIN LANGUAGE	Icelandic
MAJOR RELIGION	Christian
CURRENCY	Icelandic króna
LIFE EXPECTANCY	79 years
PEOPLE PER DOCTOR	307
GOVERNMENT	Multi-party republic
ADULT LITERACY	99%



Land use

The Icelandic people live in the more fertile coastal areas where 11 per cent are employed in farming, mainly raising sheep. Only about one per cent of the land is used for growing crops. No-one lives in the rocky centre.

Reykjavik

Heated by geothermal water from boreholes, Reykjavik is a clean, modern city, and home to about 100,000 people. It is a bustling hub of culture, industry, commerce, and government.



Brightly coloured houses in Reykjavik's old town

People

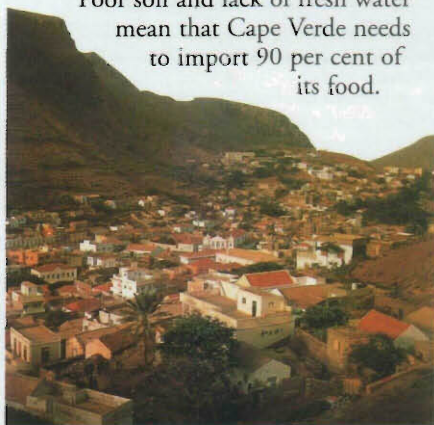
The first settlers in Iceland arrived from Norway in the 9th century. Today, Iceland boasts a classless society, and around 80 per cent of Icelanders own their own home. Most people live in towns where the standard of living is high, with extensive social security, health services, and free education.



Cape Verde

 The volcanic Cape Verde islands are divided into the Windward and Leeward islands. They lie in the Atlantic, off Africa's west coast. Until 1975, they were a Portuguese colony.

Poor soil and lack of fresh water mean that Cape Verde needs to import 90 per cent of its food.



CAPE VERDE FACTS

CAPITAL CITY	Praia
AREA	4,030 sq km (1,556 sq miles)
POPULATION	428,000
MAIN LANGUAGES	Portuguese, Creole
MAJOR RELIGION	Christian
CURRENCY	Cape Verde escudo

São Nicolau

The island of São Nicolau in the Windward Islands has many Portuguese colonial-style buildings. Most of the people here are Portuguese-African Creole. Where they can, they grow bananas and sugar-cane.

Atlantic Islands

The Atlantic Ocean contains hundreds of islands. Some, such as the British Isles, are part of a continent. Others, like the Azores and the Canaries, are volcanic. Ascension, Bermuda, St Helena, and other small islands are the summits of undersea mountains and volcanic in origin.



Falkland Islands

The Falklands, with an area of 11,960 sq km (4,617 sq miles), are a British dependent territory off the coast of Argentina – which calls them Las Malvinas, and claims ownership. Until oil was found in their waters, most people were sheep farmers.

Canary Islands

The Canary Islands off northwest Africa are governed as two provinces of Spain. Popular with tourists, the seven islands and six islets have a total area of 7,270 sq km (2,807 sq miles), and a population of 1,630,000.

